

Chapter 4

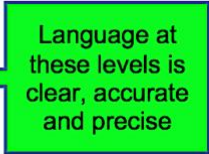
Grammar for IELTS

Understanding grammar in IELTS

How is grammar tested in IELTS?

IELTS does not have a separate paper that tests you on grammar. Nevertheless, like vocabulary, it has an impact on all parts of the test, from your ability to understand reading passages in a precise way, to your ability to explain your own ideas clearly. If we see the words that you know as your ingredients, then grammar could be compared to the 'cooking skills' that help you to alter and combine these to create meaningful sentences. It is the combination of a wide vocabulary and good grammatical skills that make your ideas clear, accurate, precise, and help you to reach a high score in IELTS.

CEFR		IELTS Bands
Proficient user	C2	8.5 - 9
	C1	7 - 7.5
Independent user	B2	5.5 - 6.5
	B1	4 - 5
Basic user	A2	3 - 3.5
	A1	1 - 2



Common problems

Creating 'complex' sentences

As with cooking, once you have a good knowledge of the basics, you can gradually develop more sophisticated skills. Just as you cannot skip basic cooking techniques to become a good chef, you cannot skip language levels A2 to B2 and jump to level C1, which is what many people try to do. The result is a confusing mix of B1 and B2 language with some learned 'complex' phrases mixed in. Success is achieved when you can consistently produce the same level of language. You cannot trick the examiner into believing you are a band 7 or 8 candidate by simply adding some 'high-level' structures to your writing. As we saw with vocabulary, it is your mastery of A1-B2 level structures that will help you achieve band 7 or above, not your attempts to use C1-C2 structures.

Key idea: Success is achieved when you can consistently produce the same level of language. You cannot trick the examiner into believing you are a band 7 candidate by just adding some 'high-level' structures to your writing.

What are complex structures?

If we look at the descriptors for Grammatical range and accuracy, we can see that candidates at bands 7 to 9 make few errors, and use a variety of complex structures. But what do we mean by 'complex structures'?

Band	Grammatical range and accuracy
9	• Uses a wide range of structures with full flexibility and accuracy; rare minor errors only occur as 'slips'
8	• Uses a wide range of structures • The majority of sentences are error-free • Makes only very occasional errors or appropriacies
7	• Uses a variety of complex structures • Produces frequent error-free sentences • Has good control of grammar and punctuation, but may make a few errors
6	• Uses a mix of simple and complex structures • Makes some errors in grammar and punctuation but they rarely reduce communication

When we first learn a language, we form very basic sentences:

I like apples.

I like bananas.

I don't like oranges.

We then learn to join these together, in a simple way:

I like apples and I like bananas.

I like apples but I don't like oranges.

As we progress, we learn to express the same ideas in more complex ways:

Although I like most fruit, I don't really enjoy eating oranges.

This is now a complex sentence. Of course, in the writing test, you are not going to be asked to write about something as simple as your likes and dislikes. Instead, the topic and question will be complex, and so it will force you to write and explain much more complex ideas, like this:

Although fresh fruit and vegetables have greater health benefits, many people would rather eat fast food.

Candidates at bands 3 to 5 will struggle to communicate ideas like this because they have a basic knowledge of language and are most confident expressing familiar ideas. As they are limited to using words like *and*, *but*, *so*, and *because*, their sentence structures tend to be repetitive. On the other hand, at the band 7 to 9 levels, candidates can skillfully connect their ideas through the accurate use of a variety of connectors such as: *although*, *despite*, *thus*, *in contrast*, *as a result*, and *consequently*.

High-level candidates can also accurately and effectively use tenses and verbs to make it clear whether they are discussing a general fact, or a possible, probable, or hypothetical situation. They can explain the causes and possible effects of something, and they can use pronouns to link ideas without repeating key words or confusing the reader. Accuracy and clarity in discussing ideas like this will naturally create '**a variety of complex structures**'.

In the gap between these two stages, band 6 to 6.5, candidates think in a mechanical way about language. These candidates often feel frustrated because they believe they have already made a great deal of progress. One recently told me, '*You don't understand, last year I didn't even know about the conditional.*' But candidates at this level are generally unable to explain complex concepts like those listed above without thinking about the mechanics of language. In the writing chapter, I compare this to learner drivers who are still focused on the controls and pedals their feet must learn to operate. When you can focus on clearly communicating your ideas, automatically using the appropriate tenses and structures that help achieve this, then you will have achieved a high band.

Complex + Complex = Complicated

Many of the band 6.5 examples I see contain very long sentences that sometimes run over three lines of the page. This is because people mistakenly believe you must use as many long, complex structures as possible to achieve a high band. In fact, this can lower your score, because the resulting sentences make your ideas difficult to follow. You will see an example of this in the writing task 2 chapter. As with vocabulary, your grammatical skill is not measured in quantities, or by the length of your sentences, but by your ability to explain ideas clearly and connect them together logically. This means that there is a link between grammatical accuracy, and coherence and cohesion. In other words, how easy it is for the examiner to understand and follow your ideas.

If you aim to explain complex ideas in a complex way, the result is complicated language. This is like trying to climb up the IELTS mountain while performing gymnastics; your efforts hold you back rather than helping you to climb higher. Your first priority in IELTS should always be to explain your ideas as clearly as you can, not to hide your ideas with confusing grammatical gymnastics.

Key idea: If you explain complex ideas using long, complex sentences, your ideas become complicated and difficult to follow. Make the examiner's job easier, not more difficult; a confused examiner means a lower score.

Deliberate Practice for IELTS grammar

Like vocabulary, grammar plays an important role in establishing the tone and style of your writing. For the academic module, the official IELTS website tells us you must write 'in a *formal* style,' while in General training, you must be able to write in a formal, semi-formal, or informal way. Let us consider the impact grammar has in different parts of the test.

Writing task 1

In Academic Writing Task 1, you need to summarise and describe visual information. Doing this 'in a formal style', means that your writing should be impersonal. So, it is not appropriate to use personal pronouns such as, 'We can see...' or 'I can see...' Similarly, when describing a process, you should write, '*The cereal is packed into boxes and sold*' rather than '*Someone packs the cereal into boxes and sells them.*' Be aware of tenses when describing changes over time, for example in a graph. Look at good model answers to see how tenses are used accurately in this way. Again, the **Official Cambridge Guide to IELTS** and **Common Mistakes at IELTS intermediate** have exercises to help you work on this.

For General Training task 1 you need to write a letter. Grammar plays an important part when it comes to explaining *what happened / has happened / is happening / you would like to happen*. So GT candidates should also pay particular attention to verbs and tenses.

Being precise

Grammar can help you to be more precise, or it can present an accuracy problem if you are not aware of the difference that even a small change in language can make. For example, consider the impact the underlined prepositions have on the meaning of the following sentences:

1. In 1980, 10% of students were male, but in 1990, this figure rose by 50%.
2. In 1980, 10% of students were male, but in 1990, this figure rose to 50%.

Can you match the sentences to the correct image (Figure A and B) below?

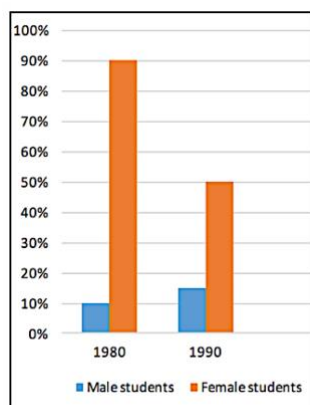


Figure A

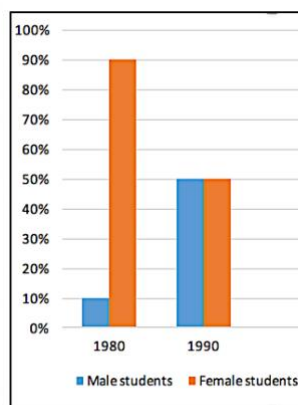


Figure B

Sentence 1 matches image A. So, if you were to write this in a summary of the data in image B, then you would not be precise and accurate in the way that you describe the information. In General Training, similar grammatical problems can make your writing imprecise or confusing. Your manager would be confused if you wrote, 'Our team was extremely successful last year and sales *rose by 50% from 2%*'. Hopefully you can see from these examples that practice for GT is useful for academic students and vice versa.

Using the correct style and tone in task 1

The verbs and tenses you use also have an impact on the tone of your writing. For example, as Academic writing task 1 must be impersonal, it is not appropriate to give advice, or your own opinions. Look at these examples and decide which one is **not** appropriate.

1. The data shows the changes the government *should make to* energy prices.
2. The data shows the changes the government *has made to* energy prices.

(Answer: Sentence 1 is giving an opinion, so is not appropriate for the Academic module.)

With General Training, it is very important to use a tone that is appropriate for the situation and the person you are addressing. Look at these examples and decide which one has the correct tone for a formal letter to your boss:

1. Give us better equipment so we can work more efficiently.
2. If employees had better equipment, we would be able to work more efficiently.

(Answer: Both sentences are grammatically correct but the first one is too direct and so less polite. The tone of the second sentence is more appropriate for a letter to your boss.)

Key idea: Grammar has an impact on how precise your writing is and the tone of your writing.

Grammar and coherence

As I mentioned earlier, grammatical accuracy can also affect the coherence of your writing. Grammatical problems make the reader confused and prevent us from fully understanding an idea. Compare the following two versions of this sentence:

1. Figure predicted rising from 2020 to 2025. (incorrect and confusing)
2. This figure is predicted to rise between the years 2020 and 2025. (correct and clear)

An example from my Facebook page can help illustrate this problem further. One of my followers asked me which of the following sentences was correct:

1. *Have the third-year term started, it will no longer be too long for my commencement day to come.*
2. *Has the third-year term of bachelor degree started, it will no longer be too long for my commencement day to come.*

I was confused about the meaning, so I had to ask some more questions to check what he was trying to say. The part of the sentence I found the most confusing was: '*no longer too long for my commencement day.*' My follower explained that he was actually trying to practise using the conditional to be able to create 'complex' sentences in the writing test.

We use the conditional tense when, or if, there is a condition. In other words, when one event or action is dependent on a different event or action in the sentence. So, it would be more accurate to write: '*When the third term begins, I will not have to wait too long for my start date.*' Or, '*When the third term begins, my own start date will not be too far away.*'

The lesson to learn from this is that this person was practising for the test by writing in a 'complex way', but your examiner is looking for *clear ideas*, so that is what you should practise producing.

Key idea: Forcing complex grammatical structures into your writing will not help you to jump a band. Only use complex structures if they help to explain your ideas in a clear and precise way.

Editing and correcting

The most common grammatical mistakes I see in writing task 1 relate to the use of:

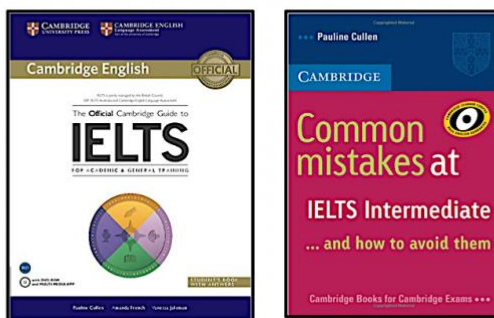
- Articles
- Tenses
- Prepositions
- Relative clauses
- Verb and subject agreement

In this quiz you will find 6 sentences with a grammatical problem from the list above. First, match the sentences to the grammatical mistakes, then correct the mistakes.

1. The chart shows that UK imported more coal in 2010 than US.
2. Number of cars on the roads has increased steadily since 1980.
3. The percentage of houses with solar power are increasing each year.
4. By 2002, the figures increased to 60% and 75% respectively.
5. The cans travel by the conveyor belt until they reach to the packing area.
6. The three countries had the most exports were China, Japan and Thailand.

You can find the answers on my website: www.keytoielts.com/

Find more exercises like this in **Common Mistakes at IELTS Intermediate** and **The Official Cambridge Guide to IELTS**.



To help develop your editing and checking skills, go back over previous task 1 answers you have written to see if you regularly make any of these mistakes.

Grammar issues in writing task 2

When researchers describe their studies in an academic journal or paper, they generally use the passive voice (though this is now changing). The passive is used to show that the study is objective and could be repeated by any one. When it comes to writing task 2, it is important to remember that you are being asked to write in a *formal* style, you are *not* writing an academic paper. A common mistake I see is candidates using the passive inappropriately in task 2, perhaps because they are following advice that says you '**must only use the passive**'.

Using the passive appropriately in writing task 2

As we saw with academic writing task 1, the passive voice is used to remove or hide the subject of the verb. In task 2, you might use it to make a general statement, or perhaps as a useful way to avoid repeating the language in the question. Look at the following examples:

1. Many **people** now **use** social media as a news source rather than just a way to communicate with friends. (active)
2. Social media **is** now often **used** as a news source rather than just a communication tool. (passive)

Governments and businesses sometimes use the passive to show, or suggest, that the whole organisation made a certain decision. Compare these examples:

1. **I have cancelled** the plan to build a new cafeteria because **I felt that we should spend** the money on new machinery. (active)
2. The plans to build a new cafeteria **have been cancelled** because **it was felt that** the money **should be spent** on new machinery. (passive)

Any employee reading the first sentence would understand that the writer is responsible for these decisions. With the second sentence, the passive is used to 'hide' the subject of the verbs 'cancel', 'feel', and 'spend', so we do not know who made the decisions.

Thus, it is important to be aware that, if your task 2 question asks, 'To what extent do **you** agree or disagree?' and you write, '**It is agreed** that...' or '**It is felt** that...', then you are *not* answering the question, because the passive hides the subject of the verb. So, advice that says '**you must only use the passive**' does not apply in task 2, where you *must* tell the examiner what you think, feel, or believe. Look back at your previous task 2 answers to see if you often use the passive in this way.

Key idea: In Writing Task 2, if you write only in the passive, you are likely to be hiding your own views, which will lower your score in the test.

Common Mistakes at IELTS Intermediate shows you how to use the passive appropriately in the writing test.

20 When do I use the passive?

1 Tick the correct sentence in each pair.

1 a Many people have been died because of this disease.
b Many people have died because of this disease.

2 a This data took from 2002 and 2012.
b This data was taken from 2002 and 2012.

With active verbs we usually use the following order: subject + v
passive when we want to put the object of the verb first: object + v
The teacher told the students to close their books. = active (subj + v)
The students were told to close their books. = passive (object + v)

We use the passive:

- when we want to make the object the focus of the sentence: *There was a small profit at the school.* (the focus is on the books, not the teacher)
- ☆ Note that the verb (*were*) agrees with the object (*the books*).
- when the context tells us who carried out the action: *A law was passed to protect people in this situation.* (we know that the government passed the law)
- when it is not important who carried out the action: *In the factory, the shoes were made and packed into boxes ready for sale.* (we do not need to know who does the packing)
- ☆ Note that we can include the 'subject' by adding *by* + the person/group: *The materials could be recycled by large manufacturers.*

2 Correct the mistake below.

Protective headgear should wear at all times.

Protective headgear

3 Change the following sentences from active to passive. You will not need to change the tense. You will need to decide when to leave out the subject.

1 A factory worker checks each box for quality. *Each box*

2 The government does not permit children under 16 to work. *Children*

3 The washing machine is washing your clothes at the moment. *Your clothes*

4 A mechanic will repair your car this afternoon. *Your car*

5 The agent has sold our house at last. *Our house*

6 Something tore the back of my coat. *The back of my coat*

7 The employer pays the staff more for working at the weekend. *The staff*

8 Burning tyres give off highly toxic chemicals. *Highly toxic chemicals*



NB This book can help you reach higher than band 6 - candidates at **ALL** levels makes these mistakes.

Expressing your views using impersonal language

The writing task 2 band descriptors tell us that a band 7 candidate will 'present a clear position throughout'. Using grammar in an accurate and precise way can help you to do this. Let us imagine that your question contains the following view: 'Many people believe that traveling is very dangerous now.' Look at sentences 1-3 and decide if they belong in a paragraph that

- A. completely agrees with the statement
- B. partly agrees with the statement
- C. disagrees with the statement

1. If traveling **was** so risky, fewer people **would** do it.
2. **Admittedly**, traveling **alone in certain areas can be a little** risky.
3. Traveling overseas **is far too** risky nowadays.

(Answers: 1C, 2B, 3A)

Look again at the sentences and think about how the highlighted structures help to communicate the writer's position. It is important to remember that when you write *'traveling alone can be a little risky'* you are conveying your own view; the reader understands this as: *'I believe this can be a little risky.'* Similarly, when you write 'Governments must...' or 'Businesses should...' You are giving your own view about what 'must' or 'should' happen. In this way, your own view is conveyed through your use of language *throughout* your essay.

Although these examples show how language can be used to reveal your view or position, you must also clearly express your own personal conclusions and feelings about the issue you are writing about. To do this, it is perfectly acceptable to write *'I completely agree...'*, *'I feel...'*, *'I believe...'*, *'In my view...'* etc. So, although you should aim to write in a general and less personal way, you do not need to completely avoid using subject pronouns in task 2.

Studying grammar

In 1973, when I started high school, most language teachers used what is called the audio-lingual method. This system is based on the theory that learning a language is like developing a new habit, and the best way to do that, is to repeat set phrases over and over. So, my French teacher would enter the classroom carrying a large screen, a projector, and a tape recorder. She would show us images of a cat, a dog, a monkey, and a table, and for several months the class all chanted sentences like this in French:

The cat is under the table.

The monkey is on the table.

The dog and the cat are next to the table.

Eventually, a chair and a tree were added for a little variety. The whole class would listen and repeat the sentences without ever seeing (or understanding) the individual words. I found this both frustrating and confusing, and I was not alone. Years later, when I was studying for my teaching diploma, I was told that children used to secretly try to write the words down, which had a terrible impact on spelling.

Next came the grammar-translation method, where we learned language by translating stories and then classical literature. The weaknesses of these two methods became very clear to me in 1982 when I arrived in France as a university student and was unable to order the coffee I like or to understand the advertisements for accommodation. Even after 9 years of studying the language, I felt like a beginner, and my first few weeks in the country were a real struggle.

The washback effect

The gaps in my knowledge were not the fault of my teachers. When preparing for a test, you will only learn what is going to be assessed – thus, the focus of a test has an impact on your study and on classroom teaching. This is known as the washback effect of a test, and is an important consideration for test writers. In the 1970s, the language testing systems put a great deal of emphasis on grammar, translation, and classical literature. So, this is what my teachers focused on; it was the tests that I had to prepare for that were responsible for my inability to communicate in everyday situations.

Since the 1980s, the most widely used language teaching method has been the communicative approach, and the IELTS test aims to reflect this. In the communicative method of language teaching,

the main emphasis is on communication and authentic materials. This is why IELTS only measures your grammar through its impact on your ability to communicate your ideas clearly and precisely, and through your understanding of authentic materials related to academic or work-based situations. As we will see, this is a deliberate way of forcing you to learn the skills and language that your certificate will claim that you have. The materials we used to learn French in the 1970s would only have been authentic if there were monkeys on the café tables of Paris, and the advertisements in the newspaper were written in a beautiful, rhyming poetry.

Present, Practise, Produce

Nowadays, a good language teacher will begin by finding out what their students *need* to learn (often through a speaking activity). The teacher will then **present** this new language using authentic materials, such as a reading or listening text. Then **practise** the language using controlled, task-based exercises. After that, the teacher will encourage students to **produce** the new language through classroom games and role play, in a written task, or in real situations outside of the classroom. This method is reflected in all good course books and resources, so self-study students can also benefit from this approach.

My *Cambridge Grammar for IELTS* book uses authentic IELTS materials to present new structures, and my *Common Mistakes at IELTS Intermediate* book first **presents** the language, then helps you to **practise** the language, and finally gives you authentic IELTS materials to encourage you to **produce** the language in the same context as in the test. If you have any course books that you completed rather quickly, or some time ago, it is a good idea to review them to be sure that you did not skip any stages. For example, if you have illegally downloaded a book, and do not have the recording, then you are missing out on 'presentation' or 'practice' – key stages of language learning.

Staying focused

It can be difficult for self-study students to stay focused. As you work through a course book, it can help to be aware of *what* you are doing and *why*. For example, *'This exercise is about how to use 'since' and 'for'. And, the main difference is that we use 'since' with a point in time or a date. So, for example, 'I have been studying since 5:00'. And we use 'for' with a length of time, so we say, 'I have been studying for 30 minutes.' Now, I've done some practice, and next I'm going to try and produce the language in a short talk.'* Being aware of what you are doing and why, can help you stay focused and ensure you practise in a deliberate way.

Learning through teaching

Even better, find a study partner and teach them a language point you have learned. When we shift from student to teacher, our ability to understand and remember is greatly improved. If your study partner can understand your explanation, then it is likely that you have understood the structure. If not, you may still have some work to do. Look up the structure you are practising in several different resources until you feel you understand it, and also know how and when to use it; try to notice real-world examples of the structure when you are listening and reading. After that, practise, practise, practise, and produce, produce, produce. Eventually, you will produce the structures automatically, which will make your writing less mechanical and more natural.

If you have not studied grammar for a long time, I recommend you look for Raymond Murphy's *English Grammar in Use*. There are several different levels and they are all excellent resources. Try to set aside 10-15 minutes a day to focus solely on vocabulary and grammar. You can turn this into a habit by always doing it at a set time of day, such as while traveling home.

Beware of false friends

We often learn most about our own language when we are learning a new one. As you study, think about how the same structures work in your own language. For example, how do you:

- explain **when** something **happened** / **will happen** / **is happening now**?
- show that something **might** or **might not** happen?
- **compare two or more things**?
- **describe nouns or verbs**?
- **refer back to an idea without repeating the same words**?

Comparing English grammar with your own language can help you to understand the structures you are learning and also increase your accuracy in the test. Nevertheless, you are likely to find some 'false friends' – language that looks or sounds similar to your own language but has a different meaning or use. I often had to note false friends in French and Spanish, for example, that the Spanish word for donkey sounds similar to the French word for butter! This problem can apply to grammatical differences as well, so it is a good idea to make a list of any false friends like this as you are learning.

'Chunking' and grammar in speaking

In speaking, we naturally join words together rather than saying each word separately and in a robotic way. This is referred to as 'chunking', and the same idea can help you in your study of grammar. In the vocabulary chapter, we talked about collocation and learning which words naturally go together. Similarly, with grammar, it is important to learn which 'chunks' of language naturally go together to accurately form a structure.

In the last chapter, I recommended dividing words into different topics, and a similar approach can be used in grammar. For example, when learning a new verb, see it first as a piece of vocabulary, and learn the meaning. After that, see it as a grammatical component of your language, and study how to use the verb accurately in a written sentence, or when speaking. Think about different tense forms as well as prepositions and how the verb changes when it is used with another noun or another verb.

Learn these as language chunks, and group together verbs that behave in a similar way. Can you add any more examples to these lists?

Verbs + to + infinitive

Tell someone to do something

Ask someone to do something

Force someone to do something

Persuade someone to do something

Convince someone to do something

Verbs + infinitive

Make someone do something

Let someone do something

Verbs + from + ing

Stop someone from doing something

Prevent someone from doing something

Organising and learning language like this will benefit both your speaking and writing. I can still remember some of my own language drills from more than 40 years ago!

Learning grammar in context

In the previous chapter, I explained the benefits of learning vocabulary in context rather than from a list. Similarly, it is helpful to focus on grammar in the context of a reading passage to help you understand the impact it has on meaning. This aspect of grammar is something that self-study students often neglect to consider, concentrating instead on the mechanics of a structure. This is a little like learning to cook something without tasting the dish yourself. As we saw earlier, grammatical structures have an impact on tone and coherence. Thus, confusion about grammar can interfere with your ability to understand what you **read** or **hear** in a precise way, as well as your ability to **write** and **speak** in a clear, coherent way.

Grammar and Meaning

One useful way to focus on the meaning of grammatical structures is to look back over reading test passages once you have completed them. Study one or two paragraphs and notice how the ideas are connected; underline each verb and ask yourself what tense the writer has used and why. Then think about how the different tenses affect the meaning and tone (especially the use of modals and conditionals). This will be particularly useful with reading Section 2 and 3 passages. When you are reviewing any incorrect answers, consider whether grammar played a part in your mistakes. Do the same for listening sections 3 and 4.

To make your practice even more helpful, focus on the list of five common problems I mentioned earlier, or any other problems that you have identified in your own writing. For example, if you realise that relative clauses are a particular problem for you, then try to notice them in reading passages and think about how, when, and why writers use them. Work in a systematic way, and do the same for prepositions, articles, different tenses, and so on.

Grammar and tone

As we saw earlier, your grammar has an impact on the tone of your language. In formal writing, native speakers try to be as polite as possible and often use adverbs and modal auxiliary verbs to soften their tone and language. Look at the following two sentences and decide which one conveys the message more politely.

1. **Besides**, certain words and phrases **are** too informal for IELTS, **obviously** you **should consider** the aim of the test **when you choose** words to learn.
2. **Furthermore**, certain words and phrases **may be** too informal to use in IELTS, so **it is important to consider** the aim of the test **when choosing** words to learn.

The first sentence is more personal and direct, and has quite an aggressive tone because of the vocabulary used (*besides*, *obviously*). The second sentence conveys the same message but in a much softer, less direct way. I often see the words 'besides' and 'obviously' used in a way that creates an inappropriate tone for IELTS. Look back at your own writing to see if you have ever used these words in the same way as sentence 1. Both band 6 and band 8 candidates will use these words, the difference is that the band 8 candidate will use the words accurately, appropriately, and with an understanding of style and tone, while the band 6 candidate will not. This is a further reminder that simply adding 'complex' words or structures to your writing will not magically transform your score.

What grammar points should I study?

Remember, a good teacher begins by identifying what their students *need* to learn. As a self-study student, you must try to identify the gaps in your grammatical range and accuracy. My **Common Mistakes at IELTS Intermediate** book covers the most frequent errors made at bands 5 and 6 in

IELTS writing, so it is a good place to start. As we will see in later chapters, it is when we are forced to *use* language that we become aware of the gaps in our knowledge: I did not know I lacked vocabulary related to accommodation until I had to find somewhere to live in France. So, pay close attention to the ideas you struggle to explain when completing less guided exercises in a course book.

As my vocabulary books present and practice language in a communicative way, rather than simply as lists, there are ample opportunities to focus on your grammar as well as your vocabulary within the books. Look at the following example from **Cambridge Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced**:

2 Time for a change
Time, change

Time

1.1 Answer these questions.

- 1 Has your attitude to your free time changed since you were a child? (In what way?)
- 2 What value is there in teaching history to children?
- 3 What is the best way to learn about history?
- 4 Do you think older people are more interested in the past than children are? (Why? / Why not?)
- 5 What influence do you think the past has over the present?

1.2 **04** Listen to two people answering the questions in 1.1. Which question are they answering?
Speaker 1 ____ Speaker 2 ____

When using resources like this, exploit them as much as possible and revisit exercises to focus on different aspects of language. Here, you could first focus on vocabulary and note down any gaps you have. Then repeat the exercise focusing on your grammar and the ideas you struggle to explain. You can increase the range of your grammar by listening to the speakers in the recording to see how they explain similar ideas. In the next chapters, you will learn how to review your mistakes following test practice. When doing this, always try to identify any problems with grammar that caused you to get an answer wrong.

Reading widely

You can also build up your range and your active use of grammar through wider reading. Finding a way to enjoy language is a real benefit when it comes to learning. Try to develop a sense of curiosity about language and, if possible, a keen interest in it. It can help if you read *well-written* articles, or books, about a subject you enjoy. For example, if you enjoy sport, then look for well-written books on that topic. When you find an interesting article, read it again to look at the language. Ask yourself. *'How did the writer express or connect their ideas? What language structures did they use?'* Collect sentences that appeal to you, and use them as good models. This is not to say that you should learn whole sentences to use in your essays. Instead, study the structure and then adapt it so that it becomes a natural part of your own language.

I recently read an article about a lady who lost her wedding dress when a dry-cleaning company closed down. After searching online, she finally managed to locate her dress. When I was reading, I

was struck by a sentence that neatly conveyed the importance of the discovery: 'The emotional significance of the dress far outweighed its monetary value.' Rather than learning and copying a whole sentence like this, you should look at the basic structure, try to learn it, then practise using it. So, from this sentence, you would learn: 'The ...of ... far outweighs its ...'

You can then deliberately practise by writing your own variations. Once you can confidently and accurately do this, the structure becomes part of your own language rather than a sentence you have learned. Eventually, you will be able to write sentences like this:

- The advantages of recycling far outweigh any inconvenience the process may cause.
- The disadvantages of raising taxes will far outweigh any savings the government may make.

Fluency V accuracy

When writing, we can edit and check our work to improve accuracy, but when speaking, we do not have this luxury. As we will see in chapter 9, any gaps in your language will cause you to stumble when you try to explain something in the speaking test, which will affect your fluency. Any time you pause to think about accuracy will have a similar effect. So it is important to practise fluency in grammar as well as accuracy. Be aware when you are doing 'controlled practice', where you control the sentence and the situation to improve accuracy, and when you are doing free practice, to help produce the same language in your writing and speaking. Doing this often will help to increase your fluency, because you will eventually produce the language automatically, without pausing to think.

Key idea: Do controlled practice and free practice to help you accurately produce new language without pausing to think in the test.

Staying motivated

It is very easy to find an excuse not to do something if you are not enjoying it. The less you practise, the less likely you are to make real progress, and so it is easy to lose motivation. It can help to remember that there are many different styles of learning and teaching, and what works for one person may not work for another. My advice is to explore different ways of learning to find the method that best suits you and your personality.

Unit 1 of Cambridge Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced looks at the vocabulary we use to talk about character and psychology. At the end of each unit, there is some form of IELTS test practice based on the vocabulary in the unit, and at the end of unit 1, I wrote a listening section 4 talk about the different ways of learning. Listen and complete the notes, then listen again and think about whether you can use any of these ideas to help you study. You will find the recording and notes on my website: www.keytoielts.com/

Final tips

- Don't waste time learning overly complex sentence structures - you do not need to produce paragraphs like those in the reading passages to achieve a high score in the writing test.
- Learn grammar in context not just from grammar books – pay attention to how the speakers or writers link and join ideas or how they help you to follow their ideas – if you cannot do this, you may not be using good models.
- Be aware of gaps in your active use of grammar (when speaking and writing) and try to fill those gaps – make sure that, when you learn grammar, you attempt to use it yourself as often as possible.
- To help with making your position clear in your writing, notice when and how native speakers use different structures and think about how this affects tone. How does this structure help you to follow the writer's ideas or make their position clear?

- When learning verbs, chunk words together rather than learning them in isolation, so that you learn any prepositions or other verbs that are used with them.
- Set aside a regular amount of time each day to work on grammar – even 5 minutes can be helpful.
- Balance working on accuracy (correcting and editing your mistakes, or doing controlled exercises) and fluency (producing the structures in speaking and writing).

Improve your grammatical range and accuracy with my two grammar books



Look out for the new second editions at the end of 2021